We agreed that since we were going to have to do business with each other, we should try our best to get along. Still, Tip didn't try to hide the fact that he thought I had come to Washington to dismantle everything he believed in—things he and other liberals had spent decades fighting for, starting with the New Deal.

As far as he was concerned, I was the enemy. I guess from his point of view, he was right.

My experience in Sacramento taught me that many liberal legislators believed in their cause with an almost religious zeal and were prepared to play hardball—and other games—to further it. It was no different in Washington. I'd only been in the Oval Office a few days when I became embroiled in a fight in which I had to persuade Congress to raise the ceiling on the national debt. Because of the spending excesses of the past, everyone in Washington knew the ceiling had to be raised—otherwise, the country would be broke and not able to pay its bills. But in an example of the games I later learned they played all the time, many of the Democrats tried to make it appear to the public that the first thing the new guy in the White House wanted to do after campaigning in favor of cutting the federal deficit was to raise the national debt. It was another example of the Congress flexing its muscles at the new boy in town. With a great show of reluctance, the Democrats finally relented and voted to raise the debt ceiling. Later, I learned a similar scenario played out every year: Congress approved appropriations that sent the federal deficit through the roof, then opposed raising the debt ceiling. They wanted to make the public think it was the Republican president, not Congress, who wanted higher spending.

In Sacramento, the most important lesson I learned was the value of making an end run around the legislature by going directly to the people; on television or radio, I'd lay out the problems we faced and ask their help to persuade